



TOOLBOX TALK — WEEKLY SAFETY MEETING

Millwork | Carpentry | Interior Finishes | Material Handling

WEEK 29

Date: Supervisor:

Project / Job Name:

TOPIC: Hearing Conservation on the Jobsite

OVERVIEW:

Occupational noise-induced hearing loss is the most common work-related disease in the United States. It is also entirely preventable. Unlike most injuries, hearing loss happens gradually and painlessly, which means workers often do not recognize the damage until it is significant and permanent. By the

TALKING POINTS — Read to Crew:

1. Sound levels on a millwork and finish carpentry job regularly exceed safe exposure limits. A circular saw generates approximately 100 dB. A router table generates 95 to 107 dB. A pneumatic nailer generates up to 110 dB at the operator's ear. OSHA's permissible exposure limit is 90 dB as an 8-hour average — but damage begins at exposures above 85 dB. Most tool operations on a busy job
2. Hearing protection must be worn correctly to be effective. Foam earplugs inserted loosely into the ear canal provide almost no real protection. To insert foam earplugs correctly, roll the plug into a tight cylinder, reach over your head with your other hand to pull the ear canal open, and insert the plug deeply until it sits flush with the opening of the canal. Hold it there for 15 to 20
3. For operations that generate the highest noise levels — router tables, planers, jointers, table saws, and pneumatic nailers — consider double protection: foam earplugs plus earmuffs worn simultaneously. Double protection provides approximately 5 additional decibels of attenuation beyond what either device provides alone. For workers operating these tools repeatedly throughout
4. Hearing damage affects more than your ability to hear. Workers with significant hearing loss report reduced communication ability, social isolation, increased fatigue from straining to understand speech, and elevated rates of depression and cognitive decline. These effects do not appear until years or decades after the damage occurs, which is why young workers consistently underestimate the

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS — Ask Your Crew:

Q1: What hearing protection do we have available on this site, and is everyone wearing it during high-noise operations?

Q2: Has anyone noticed changes in their hearing — ringing, difficulty understanding speech, or asking people to repeat themselves more often?

KEY SAFETY POINTS:

- Wear hearing protection for ANY tool operation exceeding 85 dB
- Insert earplugs fully — a poor fit provides almost no real protection
- Double-protect (plugs AND muffs) during router table or planer use
- Hearing damage is permanent — it does not heal, ever
- Get an annual hearing test if you regularly work in noisy environments

Crew sign-in sheet on page 2 — all 30 crew members sign on the following page.



CREW SIGN-IN SHEET

WEEK 29

By signing, I confirm I attended this toolbox talk and understand the topic discussed.

#	PRINT NAME	SIGNATURE (click to sign in Acrobat)	#	PRINT NAME	SIGNATURE (click to sign in Acrobat)
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